

PROLOGUE:

The orphanage mother watches the girl, her tired eyes softened by a sadness that goes bone-deep. Outside, the Holy City's towers pierce the sky, once blazing with symbols of divinity, now just shadows against a grim, fading world. She begins softly, as if speaking to herself as much as to the child.

"Listen, child. You cannot believe in all the gods. Why? Because believing in everything is akin to believing in nothing at all."

The words are heavy, burdened with the weight of vanished prayers and unanswered questions. She looks out the window to the temples, each one a relic of former glory, their sanctuaries echoing only with silence. The sky, once seen as heaven's doorway, now looms heavy and barren.

"When I was young, the gods were close, like distant family—familiar but felt in every breath, every sunrise. We knew them by the shapes of the stars, by the blessings that came like whispers on the wind. They seemed as near as our own shadows." She pauses, fingers tracing the worn wood of the windowsill. *"But now... now it feels as though they've drifted away, like leaves scattered from a dying tree."*

She turns to the girl, her face shadowed yet warm with a flicker of motherly care. The child's eyes are wide, her expression one of innocent faith, already straining under the weight of a world grown cold.

"You ask me if there's still reason to believe, and I know, oh, I know—it's harder every day. Here we are, in this Holy City, where every stone was placed for them, and yet look around. How many still kneel at the altars? How many cling to idols, relics that feel as hollow as statues of dead kings?" She sighs, her voice thick with bitter knowledge. *"You cannot believe in every god, child, because to do so now... is to believe in nothing at all."*

Her hands, calloused and rough from years of hard labor, reach out to the girl's, wrapping around her small, trembling fingers. The girl looks up, and the mother's gaze is fierce, a strange fire flickering within it.

"Faith, they say, can draw gods closer, can fill the empty heavens with their presence. But faith alone cannot reach what is already gone." Her voice lowers, weighted by the truth that she knows the child will have to carry. *"To believe in everything is to shout into an empty room, to speak to shadows and beg for voices that will never answer."*

She pulls back, rising, her silhouette framed by the dying light from outside. The holy city below is a dim glow against the endless darkness beyond, the flames of its dwindling belief fighting to stay lit.

"Remember this, child," her tone sharpens, colder, her voice final as stone, "hope in gods that do not answer is a fire that devours its own flame. You can call upon a hundred names, but in the end, only your own voice will answer you back." She pauses, letting the words hang like a warning.

"Pray, if you must. But know this: the gods are not coming to save you." Her voice softens, just barely, like the last ember of warmth. *"In this world, you will find no miracle but the one you make with your own hands."*

She steps away, her shadow stretching across the room like the encroaching night. *"Hold onto that lesson, girl. Hold it close. For when the dark comes to claim all else, it may be the only truth left to keep you warm."*

Alyza's Diary:

Entry 1

I heard Mother say it again tonight, to little Jakob this time. *"The gods are not coming to save you."* Poor Jakob... he looked so scared, I almost told him to forget it. But when Mother speaks, even when it's something hard, it's as though the words stay in the air, too heavy to ignore. I know she doesn't mean to frighten us—she just... wants us to be ready.

I wonder if maybe she's right. I pray, and pray, and nothing seems to change. I don't feel them the way others talk about. Is there something I'm missing? Or maybe I'm just not listening in the right way?

Entry 2

Today I watched the priests go down the city streets. They looked taller somehow, like statues come to life, all dressed in their robes and chanting names of the gods. People knelt as they passed, but all I could think was... do they believe any more than I do? Or are they just pretending, like I sometimes do?

Mother says we mustn't waste our time on gods who stay silent. But how can she be so certain? Maybe the gods are simply... waiting, watching from some other place. Or maybe... maybe she's right, and we're all alone down here. I don't like how that thought feels.

Entry 3

Mother said a strange thing today. She told me that if I'm ever lost, I should look to my own hands. "*The only miracle is the one you make,*" she said. I wanted to ask if she meant it, if that's really all we have. But instead, I nodded and smiled.

The others still believe, and I want them to keep that hope. I want them to have something to hold on to, even if it's just a dream. But for me... I don't know. Maybe the gods really aren't coming back. Maybe that's alright.

Entry 4

Tonight, when I knelt to pray, I didn't know what to say. I tried to remember all the words from before, but they felt empty. It's funny, the silence didn't feel lonely this time. It felt... peaceful, like I'd finally stopped trying so hard. I don't know if that means I've given up, but I didn't feel afraid.

It's strange, but I think I might be starting to understand what Mother meant.

Entry 5

Today I saw something incredible—a line of knights riding through the city, their armor glinting even in this dim light, like stars wrapped in steel. They looked so proud, their banners high and bright, the holy symbol of our city emblazoned on each. People stopped and whispered, some even cried. They say these knights have seen the gods' signs, that they ride to cleanse lands far beyond the city walls. I wish I could believe like they do. They look so certain.

But when I looked at them, I wondered how many would return. No one wants to speak of the battles that end in quiet processions rather than cheers. Even Mother looked away.

Entry 6

A strange thing happened today. One of the older boys, Edran, said he felt the gods through his sword when he held it for the first time. "I felt them guiding my hand," he said. His face was lit up like I've never seen. But then Mother pulled him aside, spoke to him in that low voice of hers. When he came back, he looked different. Quieter, like a candle that had been blown out.

I tried to ask her why she did it, but she only looked at me with that expression—the one that makes you feel like there's something you're too young to understand. "*Better he learns now than on the field,*" was all she said. But I wonder... is that really a kindness? Or are we all just trying to protect ourselves from some truth?

Entry 7

We've heard rumors of shadows spreading to the north, of whole towns overtaken by something dark, unseen. The priests hold extra prayers in the temples, but people look at each other in ways I've never seen before—doubt and fear flashing in their eyes. They speak of "divine trials" and "holy punishments." I don't understand why the gods would let this happen, if they're still with us.

Mother said the shadows are nothing new. *"They've always been there,"* she told me. *"Only difference is, now people have stopped pretending."* I wanted to ask her what she meant, but the words stuck in my throat.

Entry 8

Edran left for training with the knights today. He barely looked at us, eyes fixed on something beyond the orphanage walls. When I asked if he was scared, he shook his head. But he didn't smile, either.

Mother watched him go with an expression I couldn't place—something like pride, but colder. She says we have to be brave, that our lives are our own to fight for. But I see the way she watches them leave, as if she's already counting them among the lost.

I wonder if she prays for them in secret. I'd like to think she does, even if it's just for us.

Entry 9

It happened again. Another priest came to the orphanage today, speaking of faith, of duty. He wanted to lead us in prayer, to gather the orphans in the temple. Some of the children knelt willingly, clutching their hands tight, but I... I just couldn't feel it.

Mother watched from the back, her face stony. When he tried to take me by the hand, she stepped forward, stopped him with a single look. *"These children don't need faith that fades like morning fog,"* she told him. Her voice was colder than I'd ever heard it. *"They need to know their own strength."*

The priest looked at her like she was the darkness itself. I think I might understand why he looked so afraid.

Entry 10

Tonight, the city was alight with torches. A procession went through the streets, people praying louder than ever. The knights had returned, but not in victory. I could see the fear and pain on their faces, the empty saddles where comrades should've been. I heard them whisper of strange creatures, shadows with eyes that burn, of the silence that fell over the fields.

Mother kept us inside, telling us it's not our place to meddle in such matters. But I stayed by the window long after everyone else left, listening to the fading voices. If the gods have any answers, they keep them to themselves.

Entry 11

Mother was ill today. She says it's nothing, just the cold getting to her, but she's never taken to bed like this before. I sat beside her, watching as she slept, listening to the small, rasping sound of her breathing. She looked different, so... fragile.

I'm afraid to think of what might happen if she's gone. I wonder if this is how people felt when the gods went silent, if they felt the ground shifting under their feet, leaving nothing solid to hold on to. I don't know if I could keep going without her. I don't know if I'm ready to face the silence alone.

Entry 12

Mother hasn't left her bed in days. The other children are starting to notice, their eyes filled with questions I can't answer. I tried to pray tonight, just once, just in case... but the words felt hollow, like stones in my mouth. Maybe it's because I know she wouldn't want that. She'd tell me to be strong, to take up her lessons. But it's hard. I don't know if I have her strength.

Entry 13

Mother spoke to me today. Her voice was weak, just a whisper, but her words were as clear as ever. *"The gods may be silent, but we do not need them to be strong."* She looked at me, her gaze so intense I felt it burn. *"Remember, child. You don't need to kneel before anything or anyone to find your way."*

She smiled then, just a small, tired smile, and squeezed my hand. *"I'm proud of you,"* she said. The words broke something inside me, and for the first time in years, I cried. She looked so proud, so certain, even as her light was fading.

Entry 14

Mother is gone. She passed in the night, her hand still holding mine. I felt the life leave her, like a candle snuffed out, leaving only cold and shadow behind. The other children don't know yet. They're asking for her, wanting to hear her voice, to see her smile.

I don't know how to tell them. I don't know how to fill the emptiness she left behind. I feel like I'm staring into an abyss, waiting for something to pull me under. But I can't let that happen. I have to be strong, for them. She would've wanted that.

Entry 15

Today, I took her place in the orphanage. The other children look to me now, and I try to keep her teachings alive in the only way I know how. I tell them the things she told me, her lessons about strength, about facing the world without fear. I try to smile like she did, to be as warm as she was, even as something in me grows colder, harder.

The city around us feels emptier. People pass by the orphanage without a glance, their prayers quieter, their faces pale. Even the knights seem fewer now, their armor tarnished, their banners faded.

Entry 16

I walked the city tonight, just past sunset, when the light fades but before true dark. The streets were nearly empty, save for a few shadowed figures who, like me, seemed to wander without purpose. There's something haunting about the city at night now—a sense of grandeur lost, an echo of something that was once beautiful but is now... hollow.

I feel like I'm seeing it with new eyes. The holy statues look like strangers, cold and worn, their eyes cast downward as if ashamed. The great towers and temples, the places we were taught to revere, are just stone and silence now, their lofty heights mocking the hopes we've placed upon them.

"When the gods vanish," I whisper to myself, "what are we left with but stone and shadow?"

There's something lonely about that thought. And yet, there's also freedom in it—a strange, unsettling freedom that calls to me, telling me there's more to this world than these empty halls, these silent statues. Maybe faith was never meant to be something fixed in place. Maybe it's not in kneeling, not in statues or in stars, but in the act of moving forward even when there's nothing left to guide us.

Mother used to say that *"faith isn't about gods; it's about strength, about looking into the dark and daring to see light."* I never truly understood until now. There's a part of me that longs to leave, to feel the earth under my feet, to walk until I've shed these walls like a second skin.

I think... maybe it's alright if the gods stay silent. Maybe I am meant to find my own answers.

"Stone and shadow," I murmur again. And yet, it doesn't frighten me. I'm more than these walls, these statues. I am not meant to linger here, worshipping ghosts.

The night is calling, and I think, just maybe, I'm finally ready to answer.

Entry 17

I think it's time. The city is a hollow shell, a place of shadows clinging to what once was. The walls whisper of stories that have long gone quiet, stories of warriors and saints who once lit these halls with hope. But now, there's nothing here but memories like faded smoke, lingering and clinging to bones that should have crumbled ages ago. I feel Mother's words heavy in my heart, urging me forward, as if she's still beside me, nudging me toward the door.

I wonder if there's light left somewhere beyond these walls, a place where I can breathe without the weight of a thousand ghosts pressing down on me. She always said faith is like fire—it should move, shift, burn with purpose. Perhaps my purpose lies beyond these ancient stones. Maybe the silence isn't an ending but an invitation, a dare to walk forward with nothing but my own strength.

I'll carry her words with me, her fierce will, the way her eyes looked when she spoke about courage as if it were something living, something wild. Maybe, just maybe, I can find a spark of that out there—a truth, a fire to kindle my own, or at the very least, a place where my voice can rise above the silence.

There's nothing left to hold me here. I've packed my things, and I'm ready.

"The gods are not coming to save you." She told me that. And now, I think I finally understand what she meant.

Alyza's Diary - Leaving the Holy City:

Entry 18 – Bayshade

Bayshade is a world unto itself, loud and brazen, with streets that feel alive, pulsing like veins feeding into a heart I can't quite see. It's my first time by the ocean, and the scent of salt and fish and something else—something almost like freedom—hangs in the air. The people here are strangers to me: tieflings with their sharp horns and wary glances, orcs as large as boulders with

voices deep as caves, and genasi whose skin sparkles with elements, fire and water, earth and air walking beside me.

I can't help but stare, and yet it's not all wonder. There are cages here, too, chains, collars around necks that were meant to be free. Slaves line the marketplaces, their faces hollow, resigned as though their spirits have been beaten down to fit in the spaces between those iron bars. Some stare right through me, like they've already faded into shadows. I heard a seller shout the price of a young elf boy, barely older than me, his wrists bound, his gaze a silent plea.

Mother once said that faith was a sword meant to cut through suffering. But here, faith seems to be a whisper drowned by coins and chains. I wonder, is this the world the gods left behind, or is this what we made of it in their silence?

"The soul is its own chain," I murmured as I turned away, and I felt those words echo back at me from every shadow in Bayshade.

Entry 19 – Bayshade (2nd Day)

Today, I met a tiefling woman selling spices from a worn cloth on the ground. Her horns curved back like a ram's, her tail flicking with each gesture as she spoke, quick-witted, her laugh bright despite the hardships I could read on her face. I bought a handful of saffron, just for the scent of it, golden and rare.

She noticed me watching the slaves again, and her smile faded. *"Keep walking, little bird,"* she said in a voice that was both gentle and hard. *"The world is heavy. Learn to carry only what you must."*

It feels strange, meeting people who have lived such different lives, carrying so many burdens, yet managing to hold on to some sliver of light. And I realize now that not all cages are made of iron—some of them are the things we hold close, the beliefs we let bind us without even knowing.

"A bird caged in gold is still not free," she whispered to me as I left, her eyes bright with some spark I could not name.

Entry 20 – The Empire

We crossed into the Empire under a sky that seemed choked with smoke, a thick, gray blanket pulled tight over the land. The smell here is sour, the air heavy, unnatural, stinging my lungs with every breath. Smoke stacks rise like columns of a temple built to industry, to machines and iron and endless toil. It feels like a god itself, a metal beast that demands sacrifices of land, nature, and spirit.

Children weave through the streets here like rats, darting in and out of alleyways, each one a shadowy reminder of the orphans I left behind. I watched one boy, maybe ten or so, trying to sell scraps of wire to passersby. His face was grimy, hardened in ways I've never seen before, yet his eyes—sharp and piercing. I gave him a coin and asked his name. He laughed, a bitter sound, and said, *"Names don't matter here. Only who you can fool and what you can keep."*

What kind of world is this, where even a child's laughter carries a blade?

"When faith is gone, steel becomes its own prayer," I whispered, watching him disappear into the smoke.

Entry 21 – The Empire (2nd Day)

Today I wandered farther into the heart of the city. Every step feels like a descent, the roads slick with soot and oil, a place where even the stones seem weary. I tried to find a temple, some place of solace, but there are none. No gods are honored here. The factories are their altars, and the ceaseless grind their hymns.

I met a woman, her face wrinkled like old parchment, who sat outside one of these factories, her hands clasped around a worn piece of cloth. She told me it was a scrap from her son's shirt, the only piece left after the machines took him. *"Nothing left to believe in but the dust,"* she murmured, her voice cracking.

The people here are chained in ways that can't be seen, bound to the rhythm of iron, earth traded for smoke, life traded for power. And I wonder, how long can a people live without hope? Without something greater than themselves to hold onto?

"When faith crumbles, what rises is not strength but hunger," I wrote tonight, though I don't know if those words can capture the hollow ache of this place.

Entry 22 – Altmira

Altmira shines, but it's a tarnished gleam, polished just enough to hide the cracks beneath. The knights here wear their armor like they were born in it, walking with that grand sense of purpose I once imagined in fairytales. They carry swords etched with their family crests, voices ringing with honor and loyalty. Yet behind it all, I see beggars by the roadside, townspeople glancing away as if their pride has wilted under some unseen weight.

I saw a knight today, handing out bread from a basket to those on the street, his expression somber as if each loaf were a confession. But then, as he walked away, a sneer crept across his face when he thought no one was looking, tossing a piece of stale bread to a beggar as if feeding a stray. And I thought, this is not the honor I was taught, not the nobility I dreamed of.

"Valor without kindness is but a polished lie," I whispered to myself, feeling my heart harden just a little more.

Entry 23 – Altmira (2nd Day)

Another day in Altmira, and the shine fades faster with each step. I watched a knightly ceremony today, grand and regal, filled with speeches of duty and virtue. Yet, when the banners fell and the crowds dispersed, I saw them slip into the dark alleys, trading whispered words and golden coins with merchants whose goods I dare not name.

I met a merchant in the square, a man whose eyes followed the knights with a smirk. *"They wear steel, girl, but their hearts are iron,"* he said, almost laughing at my surprise. I asked him if honor was just a game here. His answer was simple: *"Here, honor's as real as the gold in your pocket. Spend it wisely."*

I walked away, feeling like a thread had come loose inside me, something fraying beyond repair.

"A broken oath can never be mended; it can only be forgotten," I wrote as the sun set over Altmira's towers.

Entry 24 – The Badlands

The desert feels endless, the heat pressing down like a heavy hand. The Temple of the 4 Dunes rose on the horizon, an oasis of stone and silence, guarded by orcs who stood as still as statues. I expected cruelty, barbarism, something savage in their eyes. Instead, I found something I'd nearly forgotten—dignity, deep and undisturbed.

The orcs here are not the creatures I was told about, not beasts but people of wisdom and tradition. They spoke to me of the sands, of how each grain carries the memory of those who came before. I watched them in their rituals, priests chanting as if the earth itself were listening. They bowed to nothing but the land, and I felt a kind of reverence I hadn't felt since leaving the holy city.

"True strength is in knowing the weight of each step," a priest told me, his eyes bright and knowing. And I felt, for the first time, that I was standing in a place where faith was something real, something lived, not whispered in empty halls.

Entry 25 – The Badlands (2nd Day)

I stayed to watch their rituals again, each movement purposeful, each word spoken like a promise. They showed me the symbols etched into their weapons, marks of family and honor

that had been passed down through generations. One warrior, her skin marked with symbols of her ancestors, told me how each symbol was earned, a badge of trials faced and conquered.

They say the gods blessed this desert, and here, I believe it. It's strange, seeing what I was taught to fear as barbaric, now looking to me as wisdom, strength born of respect for the land and each other. Everything here is tied to something deeper, something ancient and unbroken.

"True wisdom isn't in knowing answers," I wrote, "but in knowing what deserves your silence."

Entry 26 - A Night of Reflection

It's strange. I've seen slaves in Bayshade, children sold like cattle. I've seen orphans and machines that darken the skies in the Empire, where even nature has been sacrificed. In Altmira, I watched honor turn to hypocrisy, silver-tongued knights polished for show. And here, in the Badlands, I've found strength where I least expected it, but it's a strength laced with bitterness.

Mother's words ring in my ears still, yet they feel like echoes in an empty hall, their meanings shifting like the sands beneath my feet. Faith is not in gods or cities or even banners; it's in the harsh reality that survival often demands sacrifice and suffering.

"We carry our faith as we carry our scars," I remind myself, but it's hard to find solace in that thought when the scars seem to multiply. The orcs, who I once feared as mere savages, have shown me a different side, yet I can't shake the feeling that I've merely exchanged one set of chains for another. Their traditions speak of honor, but what is honor worth in a world that devours the weak?

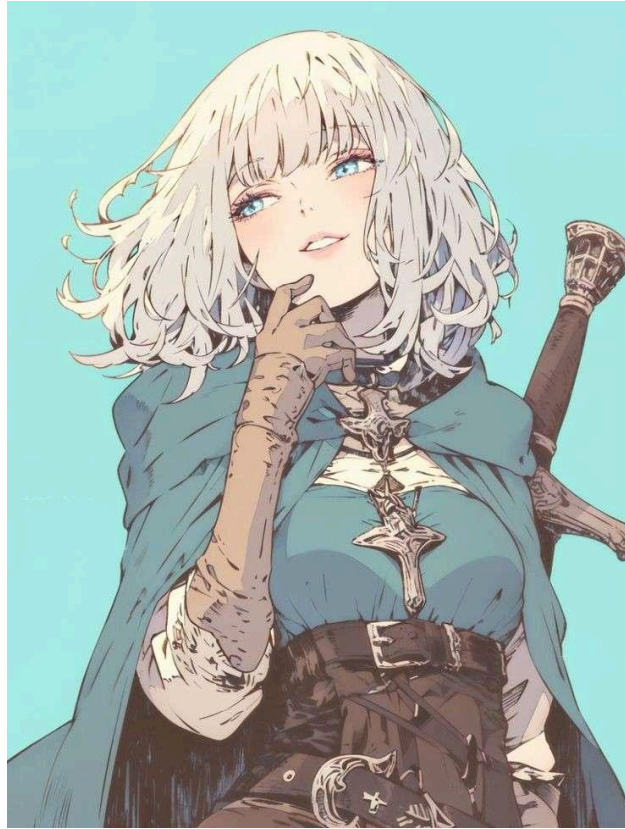
"Courage is not the absence of fear but the heart's resolve to push forward," I've heard. Yet, as I sit beneath a sky littered with indifferent stars, I wonder if courage is simply a delusion we cling to when the dark closes in. Each step I take feels like a dance with futility, as if I'm moving toward an end I cannot foresee.

There is no light here, only the unyielding expanse of sand that reflects the desolation within. I may be lost, but I am not without awareness. I can feel the weight of despair pressing down on me, a reminder that hope is a fragile thing, easily crushed beneath the harsh realities of this world.

"In every shadow, there is a chance for light," I once believed. But now, I see shadows stretching endlessly, threatening to engulf me. I wonder if I'm chasing a flicker that may never ignite. As I prepare to leave this place of contradictions, I'm left with an unsettling truth:

sometimes, the journey reveals not what we wish to find, but rather the darkness we cannot escape.

CHARACTER PORTRAIT:



"In a world abandoned by the gods, I walk through shadows, seeking truth in the silence and strength among the broken."